

RESOLUTION NO. _____

ENTITLED: "A RESOLUTION EXPRESSING THE SUPPORT OF THE GOVERNING BODY FOR THE DESIGNATION OF THE HIGH PLAINS ARBORETUM AS A STATE HISTORIC SITE BY THE WYOMING STATE LEGISLATURE."

WHEREAS, when the City of Cheyenne was established on August 8, 1867, only twelve (12) trees were located within city limits, and as early as 1882, Cheyenne residents began playing an important role in increasing the tree canopy within the city;

WHEREAS, since 1928 the City of Cheyenne has owned two thousand one hundred forty (2,140) acres of property west of F.E. Warren Air Force Base known as the High Plains Arboretum (the "Arboretum"). Beginning in 1928, the City leased the property to the U.S. Department of Agriculture ("USDA") for one hundred ninety-nine (199) years for the purpose of operating the USDA Cheyenne Horticultural Field Station (the "USDA Station");

WHEREAS, as part of President Franklin D. Roosevelt's New Deal legislation, members of the Civilian Conservation Corps ("CCC") constructed important infrastructure and several historic structures at the Arboretum. These structures include the water treatment plant resources on Round Top, much of the footprint of the original horticultural research station, including the headhouse, greenhouse and foundations, the lath house, as well as the irrigation infrastructure, parade ground, the former USDA soils lab and historic planting grounds. Notably, the Arboretum also includes Houses 1 through 4, which were all designed by prolific Cheyenne architect, and former member of the Wyoming Legislature, William DuBois;

WHEREAS, the USDA Station researched hardy trees, shrubs, fruits and vegetables that could survive the harsh Wyoming weather and climate with the intent of propagating these plants for the people of Wyoming.

WHEREAS, the mission of the USDA Station changed in 1974 from horticultural research to livestock grazing management, mined land reclamation and water conservation research. The change in mission led to the abandonment of historic tree property encompassing approximately sixty-two (62) acres, which was minimally cared for by the USDA staff from 1974 until the early 2000s when the City of Cheyenne became involved with its care and upkeep;

WHEREAS, as the grasslands research became the focus of the USDA, care for the trees and shrubs was curtailed, leaving them to rely mainly on natural precipitation to survive. Many trees perished as a result, with over fifty percent (50%) of the plants inventoried in 1974 now gone, and many more that are in severe decline;

WHEREAS, Cheyenne has experienced high mortality rates in its street tree populations resulting from an aging forest and past extreme weather events, which has caused large gaps in the tree canopy. Recognizing the need for a community tree planting program, the City of Cheyenne Division of Urban Forestry created Rooted in Cheyenne, a non-profit organization staffed by

volunteers who plant trees throughout the city. Since its creation, Rooted in Cheyenne has planted over one thousand two hundred (1,200) trees in the city;

WHEREAS, the City has also partnered with the Friends of the Botanic Gardens Foundation, which is a non-profit organization that beautifies and enriches the High Plains through gardening, volunteerism, education and stewardship. The work of the of foundation includes the support of the Arboretum;

WHEREAS, the cost of maintaining the Arboretum and appurtenant ground buildings, and ensuring the continued existence of the trees and shrubs, present-day grounds and historic CCC structures are a significant financial challenge for the City of Cheyenne;

WHEREAS, given the critical historical and cultural importance of the Arboretum and the additional support this site requires, on May 1, 2023, Cheyenne Mayor Patrick Collins formally requested that the Wyoming Department of State Parks and Cultural Resources (the "Department"), review the Arboretum as a potential historic site through its Site Criteria Process, The Department has convened a working group to evaluate the potential to administer the Arboretum as a historic site;

WHEREAS, based on conversations with multiple vested stakeholders, the Department believes that to best operate the Arboretum as a State Historic Site in collaboration with these community partners;

WHEREAS, the Department has proposed state historic site boundary encompassing eight hundred seventy seven (877) acres of the 2,149-acre property. This acreage would ensure that the Department and vested stakeholders could work to preserve and improve the buildings and other structures on site as well as maintain the appurtenant features, including roads, irrigation ditches and fencing; and,

WHEREAS, the Joint Travel, Recreation, Wildlife and Cultural Resources Interim Committee of the Wyoming State Legislature is currently considering legislation that if introduced and passed during the 2024 Budget Session would designate the Arboretum as a State Historic Site.

NOW, THEREFORE, BE IT RESOLVED BY THE GOVERNING BODY OF THE CITY OF CHEYENNE, WYOMING, hereby expresses its strong support for the Joint Travel, Recreation, Wildlife & Cultural Resources Interim Committee's sponsorship and introduction of State Historic Site designating the Arboretum as a state historic site and for the adoption of this important legislation by the Wyoming State Legislature during the 2024 Budget Session.

PRESENTED, READ AND ADOPTED this _____ day of _____,
2023.

Patrick Collins, Mayor

(SEAL)

ATTEST:

Kristina F. Jones, City Clerk